How to Mend a Hole in Your Sweater

Practice your stitches on the grid below, then apply them to a real hole. A hole in knit fabric is fixed by re-weaving the grid, handful of threads at a time.

What you need: Needle (a blunt tapestry needle is gentlest on knits), a small ball of yarn or thread that matches your sweater, sharp scissors.

Before you start

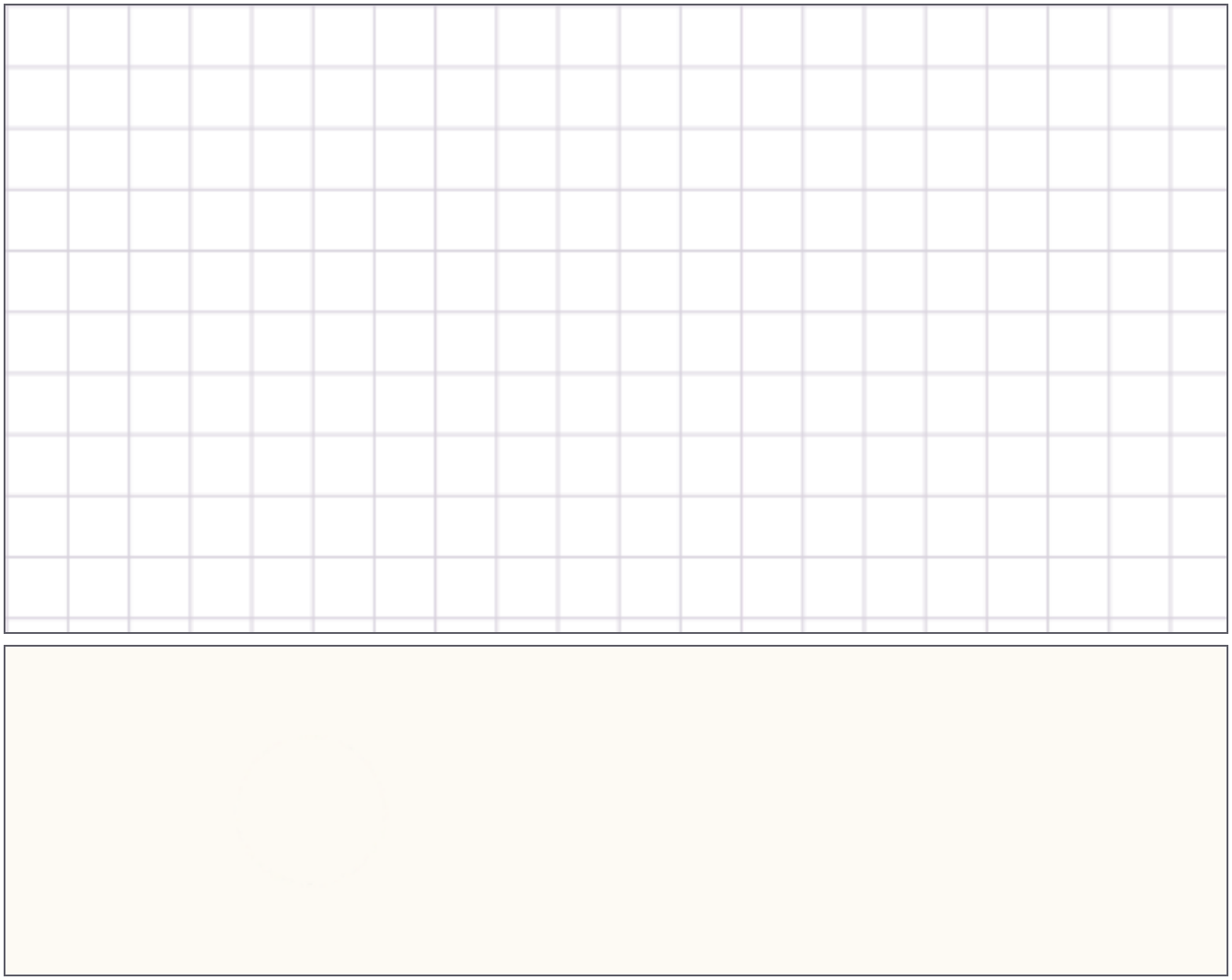
1. Trim any loose, dangling threads around the hole, but don't enlarge the hole.
2. If the hole is on a seam or underarm, handwash and dry first. Darning works on clean fabric.

Darning the hole

1. Thread a needle with yarn about 18 inches long. Knot one end.
2. Hide your knot on the inside of the knit, then bring the needle up beside the hole, about a quarter inch outside its edge.
3. Lay down several rows of straight stitches across the hole, going one way (say, up-and-down), leaving the loosest possible tension. Treat these like the warp threads of a woven grid.
4. Now turn and weave: pass the needle over one vertical thread, under the next, and come back over the reverse on the return row. This creates the perpendicular threads.
5. Continue weaving rows until the whole hole is bridged, feathering into the surrounding knit at the edges so the patch can't be felt.
6. Knot off on the wrong side of the fabric by passing the needle under a few nearby loops of knit, then trim.

Warm-up grid

Warm up your hands before you touch the sweater: practice straight rows up and down on the grid below, then weave across them the way the darning pattern shows.



In the circles below, practice a small visible mend about three-quarters of an inch across, in a thread color you love. Checking the diameter stays inside each circle trains your eye to keep mends tidy.

Kind tips: Darning works better when you keep the tension loose. Stitches pull too tight and the mend puckers. Rest your hands, take a sip of tea, and let the stitches be gentle as the sweater is.